**Draft - expert review pending**

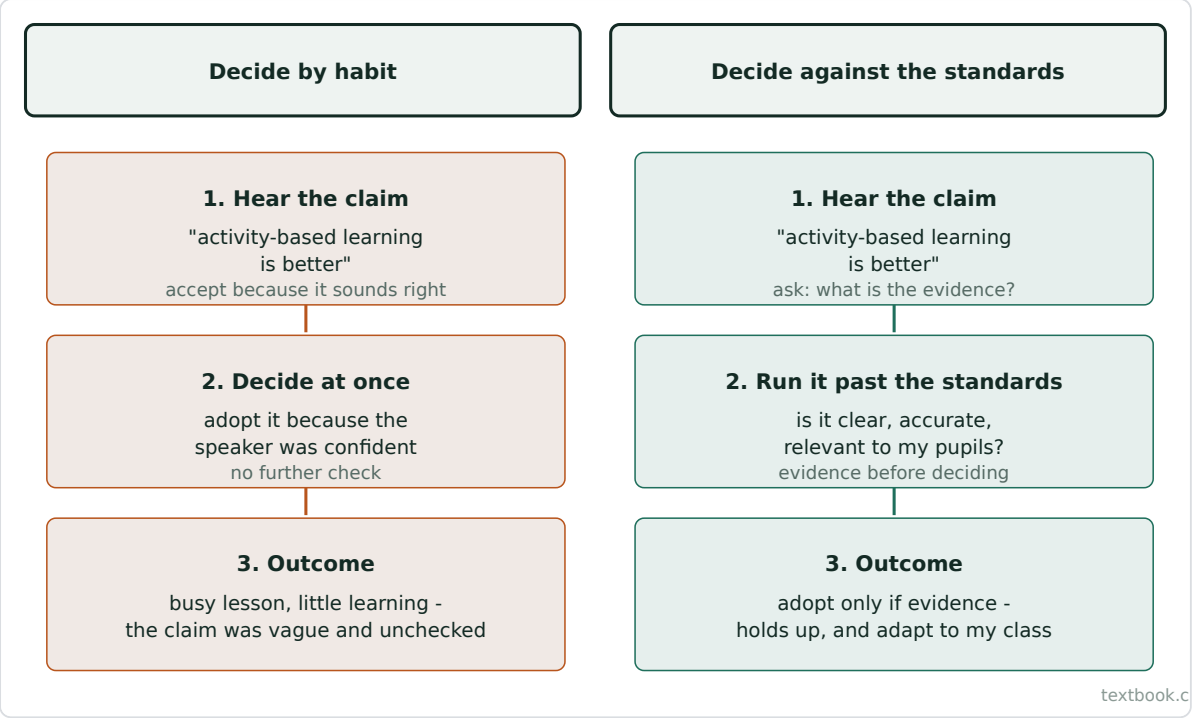
Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform’s automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

# Topic 1.2 - The standards, and what they are for

## A real classroom situation

At a school in Hyderabad, the head teacher announces that the school will adopt "activity-based learning" the following term because, he says, "children learn better when they are doing, not just listening". Several teachers nod. One teacher, Ayesha, wants to agree but is unsure whether the claim is sound or merely fashionable. She has seen activity-based lessons that were busy but taught little, and she has seen quiet direct instruction that worked well. She wishes she had a way to judge the claim rather than just trusting the head's confidence.

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Ayesha's wish is exactly what the standards give you: a checklist to apply to any piece of reasoning so that your judgement rests on something firmer than a speaker's confidence.

# Explanation

## The critical-thinking standards

Bassham et al. (2010) set out a small set of standards that good reasoning is expected to meet. Think of them as questions you put to any claim or argument. Research with teacher candidates confirms that these standards are a measurable construct: trainees' attitudes toward critical thinking predict how well they apply the standards, accounting for a large share of the variance in standard scores (Zeybek, 2025).

- **Clear** - Is it understandable? A claim you cannot paraphrase in your own words is too vague to judge.
- **Accurate** - Is it true, or at least supported by evidence? A claim that sounds plausible but has no backing fails here.
- **Precise** - Is it specific enough? "Results will improve" is less precise than "punctuation errors in weekly drafts will fall by a quarter over one term".
- **Relevant** - Does it bear on the question at hand? A true but off-point fact is a distraction, not a reason.
- **Deep** - Does it get to the real cause, or only the surface? Saying "the pupils failed because the test was hard" may be accurate without being deep.
- **Broad** - Does it consider other angles, or only the one the speaker prefers?
- **Logical** - Does the conclusion follow from the reasons given?
- **Fair** - Has the reasoning considered the strongest version of the opposing view, or only a weakened one?

You do not need to memorise the list as a chant. You need to use it as a habit: when you meet a claim, run it past the two or three standards that matter most for the question at stake.

## Benefits of critical thinking in the classroom

When a teacher applies the standards to her own planning, the benefit is better decisions. Instead of adopting a method because a workshop recommended it, she asks: *What is the evidence? Is it relevant to my pupils' age and context? Does it address the actual learning problem I face?* That habit protects against fads and against the assumption that what worked elsewhere will work unchanged in her room.

## Benefits of critical thinking in the workplace

The same habit matters among colleagues. Staffroom decisions - grouping pupils, choosing a textbook, setting homework policy - are often made on habit or on the strongest voice in the room. A teacher who asks "How do we know that is true?" or "What would count as evidence that this is not working?" makes the discussion more honest and usually more useful. Critical thinking is, in this sense, a professional responsibility, not a private talent.

## Benefits of critical thinking in everyday life

Outside school, the standards help you judge the claims you meet daily: a health remedy advertised on social media, a political promise, a news report about exam results. In each case the same questions apply - *Clear? Accurate? Relevant? Logical?* - and a person who asks them is less easily misled. For a teacher, this everyday habit also models for pupils what it looks like to take ideas seriously without taking them on trust.

> **Common misconception.** Many trainees arrive believing that "a claim and an argument are the same thing". They are not. A *claim* is a statement that something is true ("activity-based learning is better"). An *argument* is a claim plus at least one reason offered to support it ("activity-based learning is better *because* it raises test scores, as a 2019 study showed"). The standards apply to both, but an argument gives you more to judge: you can ask whether the reason actually

supports the claim. The next two topics look at these units of reasoning in detail.

## Activity: Run a claim through the standards

Work in small groups. About 20 minutes.

Take the head teacher's claim: **"Children learn better when they are doing, not just listening."**

1. As a group, choose three standards from the list above.
2. For each chosen standard, write one sentence judging whether the claim meets it and one sentence saying what would need to be added or changed for it to pass.
3. Compare your judgements with another group. Where you disagree, explain which standard you applied and why.

## Check your understanding

1. **Remember** Name four of the eight critical-thinking standards.

2. **Understand** Explain the difference between a claim being *accurate* and a claim being *deep*, using a classroom example.

3. **Apply** A colleague says, "We should ban mobile phones because they distract pupils." Apply the *relevance* and *precision* standards to that claim in one or two sentences each.

## Summary

The standards - clear, accurate, precise, relevant, deep, broad, logical, fair - are a checklist for judging any piece of reasoning. Applying them in the classroom, the staffroom and everyday life is what turns "critical thinking" from a vague compliment into a usable professional skill.


## Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can name and explain at least four of the eight standards.
- [ ] I can apply a standard to judge whether a described claim meets it.
- [ ] I can explain why a claim can be accurate without being deep.

### Try this at your practicum school

Find a written claim in your school - a notice, a policy line, or a sentence from a textbook. Choose two standards and write one sentence each judging the claim against them. Note what evidence you would want to see for the claim to pass.

## Summative task

Take the claim **"Our pupils' Urdu results dropped because the new textbook is harder."** Write a short paragraph (80-120 words) evaluating it against *three* of the eight standards. For each standard, state whether the claim meets it and give one piece of reasoning.

**Mini-rubric**

| Criterion | Levels |
|---|---|
| *Standards applied* | 0-2: three standards named and used correctly / fewer than three or misapplied. |
| *Reasoning quality* | 0-3: specific reasoning for each judgement / vague or generic / none. (**Analyze**: cites a concrete reason the claim does or does not meet the standard.) |
| *Clarity* | 0-2: paragraph coherent and within word band / unclear or over length. |

## Further reading

Bassham, G., Irwin, W., Nardone, H., & Wallace, J. M. (2010). *Critical thinking: A student's introduction* (4th ed.). McGraw-Hill. Chapter 3 sets out the standards of reasoning applied in this topic.

Zeybek, G. (2025). The relationship between critical thinking standards and critical thinking attitudes of teacher candidates. *International Journal on Social and Education Sciences*, 7(1), 36-57. https://doi.org/10.46328/ijonses.711. Confirms that critical-thinking standards are a measurable, attitude-linked construct in teacher education.

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